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TECHNOLOGY THE KEY TO INDIA'S TRANSFORMATION

The G20 presidency gives India a vital platform to take its prowess in creating population-scale digital goods to the global stage

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Exponential change starts gradually, then accelerates suddenly. India is on the verge of just such a transformation

IT'LL BE A watershed moment for India as it hosts the G20 Leaders' Summit for the first time in September this year. Made up of 19 of the world's largest economies and the European Union, the G20 members account for roughly 78 per cent of the world's trade, 85 per cent of the global GDP and two-thirds of the world population.

Initially conceived during the global financial crisis in 2008 to facilitate economic cooperation in a rapidly globalising world, the G20 presidency for India has come at a time when the world is grappling with the Russia-Ukraine war, and intensifying geopolitical tensions in the South China Sea. What's more, the world is still struggling to recover from the widespread upheaval caused by the Covid-19 pandemic. The major disruptions in food, energy and various other supply chains have left nations looking for greater self-reliance, while establishing new partnerships. This presents India with an opportunity to assert its role as a trusted partner in the post Covid-19 world.

India has aptly chosen a timely yet timeless theme of "*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*" for its G20 presidency. This Sanskrit phrase taken from India's old scriptures that means 'The world is one family', highlights the crucial need for unanimity amongst humanity in our interdependent and interconnected world, which is a pressing need of our times.

Having spent the bulk of my adult life in Silicon Valley and participating in innovating technology and watching its exponential impact, I have become a firm believer that technology has and can continue to solve the big global challenges of the world. With this conviction and an unwavering belief in India's talented youth, I had set up my first cross-border incubator, New Path Ventures, between Bangalore (now Bengaluru) and Silicon Valley, in 2002. My goal was to expose India's youth to the world of innovation and entrepreneurship. We built four start-ups around designing chips for computing, networking and telecom industries.

Shortly thereafter, I set up an early-stage venture capital fund in Bangalore in 2005. A few of my fellow Silicon Valley non-resident Indians also launched around half a dozen similar funds. Our common goal was to pioneer a Silicon Valley-style VC ecosystem to India. Our efforts ended up sparking a start-up wave in the country. Now, in less than two decades, India's start-up ecosystem has grown to become the world's third-largest, and accomplished the rare milestone of creating over 100 unicorns. These start-ups are innovating groundbreaking solutions